GREAT HOMES, SMART OFFICES

One of the fastest growing developers in Delhi NCR, Chintels Group is known for both its commercial & residential properties. In this interview, Managing Director Prashant Solomon addresses a wide gamut of topics, ranging from the inception of the Group to its continued growth despite the onslaught of the COVID19 pandemic



"Get ready for the roaring 2020s"

PRASHANT SOLOMON
Managing Director
Chintels Group

Q For the uninitiated, what is the Chintels Group all about?

We laid the foundation of the Chintels Group back in the 1980s. Initially we were aggregators of land. Then we expanded to include commercial properties in South Delhi under our ambit. We also tried our hand in the software business for a few years. It was back in 2007 that a large portion of our land bank became a part of the master plan of Gurgaon. That is when we decided to get into the development business. Initially since we were short on experience, we partnered with Sobha & ATS for a couple of projects. Then we decided to handle it on our own that is how we got into the real estate business. On the Dwarka Expressway near Delhi, we are one of the largest land owners. Our land extends across 5 different sectors in Gurugram. We are into residential as well commercial projects.

Q With the Chintels Corporate Park at the Dwarka Expressway now being ready, how has the reception been to the project?

The reception has been pretty good so far. Unfortunately the timing of the project completion coincided with the pandemic. The project meanwhile has garnered a lot of appreciation. The building is completely operational and the search for tenants is underway. Now talking about the area, with the Dwarka Expressway nearing its completion, we expect a large influx of people. Sector 114 in Gurugram where our structure has been built, is a purely commercial sector. Same is the case with sector 115, where too we have land. And our project is the only one that has reached its completion and so it has become a sort of landmark in the area. As compared to the other parts of Gurugram, our area is way closer to Dwarka & the airport. All these factors combined assure me that the area would become one of the most sought after areas of commercial & retail properties.

Q For the Corporate Park, which sector are you targeting for your potential tenants?

Our primary target would be MNCs, particularly in the IT sector. Though we are open to all corporations, including medium to large sized India companies. We are also considering turning parts of our building into a business centre & co-working space.

Q You recently made an announcement about your new commercial project in Gurugram, tell us more about it, including what comprises its USP!

Chintels Center is our next project which we are about to commence. Situated in sector 114 of Gurugram, it is very close to the Corporate Park. It would adopt a high street retail concept, on the lines of Galleria with plenty of restaurants & other avenues of entertainment. It would also have retail, anchor & multiplex hyper marts along with office complexes. It would be the first of its kind in NCR. You can consider it as a sort of hybrid between a traditional mall and high street. It is a very well positioned project. It will be completed by 2024-25.

Q Through Nora Solomon Foundation, you have been working in the areas of education, health, sanitation & relief, please throw some more light on that!

Nora Solomon was my grandmother. After she passed away, we started a foundation in her memory. It also acts as the CSR wing of the Chintels Group. Its key focus areas are healthcare & education. In our township in International City, we have started a hospital called Nora Solomon MediCenter. It is our first venture in the field of healthcare. Though we want to make it self reliant but profit is not our prime motivation. Our emphasis is on providing good healthcare to people in the area across all the economic groups. Talking about the education sector, though we are not running any school on our own but we have extended support to a number of schools in Delhi NCR & Uttaranchal. In Delhi NCR, we have been helping schools imparting education to children with special needs. While in Uttaranchal there are a number of schools in distant hills & remote villages, we are helping them by taking care of the operational expenses. That ensures that the aid provided heads in the right direction.

Q Since the time the COVID19 pandemic started, considering the tumult that the industry found itself in, how would you assess your progress in the period?

I would divide the period into two parts. First, let's talk about the first wave which came last year. There was a nation wide lockdown & except for essentials, people weren't allowed to step out of their houses. So like every other industry, we too were hit hard. But about a month later, construction activities were opened in the areas which had labour at site. Luckily for our projects we make arrangements for labour camps on site, so we could resume after near-about a month. That way our project didn't suffer much of a delay. Now if we shift our attention to the second wave that followed this year, surprisingly the real estate market in the residential segment in our part of the town fared even better than the pre COVID times. In the month of October this year, we registered our maximum number of sales ever. The probable reason for such figures is that COVID made people realize the importance of owning their own property. The year 1918 bore witness to the Spanish Flu pandemic but it was followed by the roaring 20s in the West. Courtesy the COVID19 pandemic, people have lived in lockdown for long periods with plenty of restrictions being imposed. But once the situation gets stabilized, you are going to witness an immense growth in businesses in India and abroad. We just need to have a positive attitude & keep in mind that we are all in this together. This pandemic has changed our lives forever but when we look back at this, I think there would still be plenty of positives to reflect upon.